

Hugh Aston (ca. 1485-1558): Composer and Mayor of Leicester

Patrick J. Boylan

The importance of the music of the early Tudor composer, Hugh Aston, has been recognised for a very long time, even though what was almost certainly a very substantial body of work was very largely lost during the Reformation, and only a dozen or so identified compositions by him survive. Indeed, we find a remarkable tribute to Aston's significance in the work of one of the greatest composers of the later Tudor period, William Byrd, (ca. 1539-1623) who used an otherwise now lost work by Aston as the basis of his well-known composition *Hugh Aston's Ground* (1), and variants of other Aston works were known by the late sixteenth century.

However, there has been great confusion about the actual identity of Hugh Aston (sometimes Assheton or Asseton) the composer. He was completely misidentified in the original editions of both the *Dictionary of National Biography* and *Grove's Dictionary of Music and Musicians*, and just about everything biographical about him is wrong in W H Gratten Flood's widely quoted *Early Tudor Composers*, (1925), and even in the Hugh Aston volume of *Tudor Church Music* (vol. 10, 1929). (2)

The first record of Aston the composer that seems to have been traced so far is in the Oxford University records for 27th November 1510, when he successfully applied for the award of the degree of B.Mus., submitting a Mass and Antiphon as test pieces and stating that he had been studying music in the University for eight years. (Assuming he had entered Oxford at around the age of 16 or 17, as was typical at the time, this would suggest that he was born around 1485, though there is no other information about his origins and early life.) However, the two submitted compositions seem to have been more than just approved: it was ordered that the two pieces be retained by the University. Several writers suggest that his very closely related Mass *Te Deum* and Antiphon *Te Matrem Dei* manuscripts, preserved in the Bodleian Library, Oxford, are these two diploma works. (3)

Nothing is known of him or his movements, whether in England or further afield, until 1520/21, but from then onwards he appears in the records and accounts of, or relating to, a number of important Collegiate Choral Institutions across the Midlands. (4)

The Treasurer's Accounts of the Dean and Chapter of the Collegiate Church of St Mary, Warwick, for 1520/21 (now

in the Public Record Office) show a payment to "Hugonis Asseton laborantis a Coventr" (i.e. 'working at Coventry') for travelling from and back to Coventry to advise on the purchase and installation of a new organ, (5) but there is no information as to whether he was by then permanently working in Coventry or simply there temporarily, enabling Warwick to minimise the expense. However, he seems to have had a longer-term association with Coventry's Benedictine abbey (now the Cathedral), at least in an advisory capacity, as this was one of the seven religious houses in respect of which Aston received a state pension in his retirement. (6)

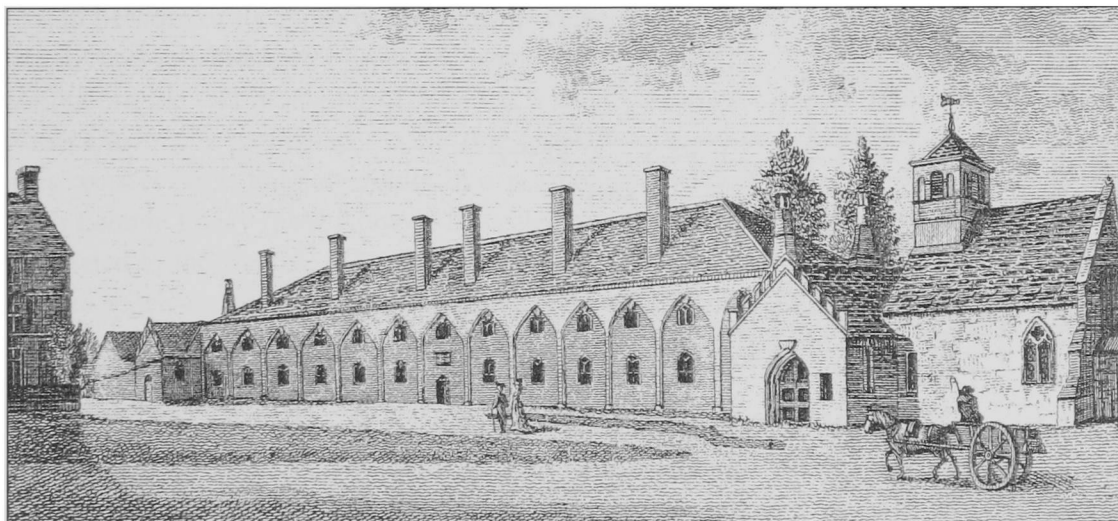
By 1525 Aston was settled in Leicester, and he seems to have remained in the town for the rest of his life. In that year he was listed as *Magister Choristerorum* [Master of the Choristers] in Bishop Longland of Lincoln's formal Visitation of the Hospital and College of St Mary, The Newarke, Leicester. This had been ordered by the Bishop in response to complaints to the Privy Council about the residence within the College of a wealthy female benefactor, Lady Hungerford, contrary to its Statutes. During this Visitation Aston was questioned under oath about his knowledge of quarrels within the College, the sworn deposition being recorded, apparently verbatim, in a mixture of Latin and English. (7)

In the early sixteenth century the famous 'Hospital and New College of The Annunciation of St Mary in The Newarke' occupied a walled area of around four acres just outside the boundary of the Borough of Leicester, immediately south of the Castle, now mainly covered by the campus of De Montfort University. However, by the time John Speed published his first plan of the town in 1611, only six decades after the institution was suppressed during the Reformation, almost all traces of this remarkable religious institution had gone, along with most of the Leicester Abbey, and other major religious establishments, notably the large Greyfriars and Blackfriars monasteries.

Today the most substantial survivals of the Hospital and College are two of the main entrances: the Newarke (otherwise Magazine) Gateway of ca. 1410 and the Turret (or Rupert's) Gateway of 1422-3 between the Castle and the Newarke enclosure, and the very much altered Trinity Hospital with its chapel of ca. 1420. The other remaining structures are William Wigston's Chantry House of ca. 1513

(now part of the Newarke Houses Museum), short lengths of the walls of the enclosure, two re-built arches of the Collegiate Church of St Mary of the Annunciation preserved in the basement of the early twentieth century Hawthorne Building of De Montfort University, and fragments of a fourteenth century building (possibly the Dean's residence) in the remains of the former St Mary's Vicarage, also now part of the University's property. (8)

First established by Henry, 3rd Earl of Lancaster, in 1330 as a chantry and hospital with an establishment of a Master, four Chaplains and five women attendants to help take care of both short-term and chronic, long-term, patients (9), the Hospital and College was re-endowed and greatly expanded by his son, Henry, 4th Earl and later the 1st Duke of Lancaster. Under the new Charter of Foundation and Endowment of 24th March 1355/6 (10) the College had, and was primarily governed by, a Dean and twelve canons or prebends. Each of these thirteen were to be served by a supporting vicar, and the canons and vicars were all to be already in priest's orders at the time of admission. There were also to be four lay clerks and six (boy) choristers, while the hospital function was expanded to provide for the care of fifty poor men and fifty poor women.



The open space in the foreground outside the Trinity Hospital in Nichols' engraving is the site of the Collegiate Church. The (? three storey) building just showing on the left hand edge of the drawing is presumably St Mary's Vicarage - one of the original medieval buildings of the College, thought most likely to have been the Dean's House, the ruins of which were recently investigated by ULAS for DMU.

The Dean and each Prebend were to have their own house inside the Close. A communal dwelling house was to be provided for the 13 Vicars complete with a kitchen, bakehouse and brewhouse, and another house was to be constructed within the Close for the six choristers. At various later dates, through to the early sixteenth century, a total of three chantries were established within the College, each with its own chantry priest and a house for him in addition, as with the surviving Chantry House of William Wigston.

The 78 Statutes, plus a number of supplementary Statutes or variants, set out in very great detail all aspects of the rules and operation of the Hospital and College, not least its liturgical activities, which were to follow the Salisbury ('Sarum') Rite. Music was clearly intended to be an important part of the life of the institution, and among many other things there had to be a daily sung Mass in honour of Our Lady, and there was a list of more than two dozen high feasts on which High Mass, Matins and Vespers had to be celebrated, led by the Dean in choir. There were other very detailed provisions relating to the choir and choral offices, including dress, attendance rules and the examination in reading and singing of both choral vicars and boy choristers before their appointment.

The wide-ranging research of Dr Roger Bowers on the English choral colleges (11) shows that by the early to middle fifteenth century these, as well as the English cathedrals and major monasteries, were using a wide and ambitious range of music, both more traditional plainsong and the newly emerging polyphonic music, typically in up to four or five parts (one or two trebles, alto, tenor and bass). There must have been a very great number of new compositions and exchanges of music scores both at the

national and international levels to meet the needs of such an ambitious liturgical and choral programme. Sadly, however, only a tiny fraction of the works that must have existed and been performed survive today, partly at least because of the recorded large-scale and organised destruction of choir books along with other liturgical books during the Reformation.

The high status and musical reputation of the Newarke collegiate institution was already acknowledged long before Hugh Aston arrived, apparently in the early 1520s. By the late fifteenth century it had acquired the extraordinary privilege, apparently shared only with the Chapels Royal, of having the right to recruit outstanding musicians and singers from other institutions without their consent, in other words to poach the very best musicians of the country. Perhaps the very highly regarded Aston was himself recruited by The Newarke using this privilege, but there seems to be no documentary evidence of exactly when or how he came to settle in Leicester.

However, once here he seems to have been determined, or at least more than content, to stay. In the mid-1520s Cardinal Wolsey offered him the post of master of the choristers at his richly endowed new Cardinal College, Oxford, now Christ Church, but Aston turned this down and John Taverner was appointed instead. (12) In Leicester his initial salary was £10 a year (the same as the Canons of the College) and he was provided with a free house just outside the Newarke Gateway in Hangman's Lane, now Newarke Street, and by 1540 this had risen to £12 a year. (13)

However, he clearly had many other opportunities for substantial additional earnings, for example for a wide range of special liturgies and services etc. For example, there are provisions in a number of Wills for payment to him for participation in funeral services, and he may well have had advisory or other retainers at several other significant collegiate institutions. In his retirement, he appears to have received not only a £12 a year State pension in respect of his position at the Newarke, but other annual pensions totalling

£6 13s. 4d. in respect of other suppressed choral institutions Sulby and Pipewell in Northamptonshire, Coventry and Kenilworth in Warwickshire, and of the Abbeys of Launde and St Mary de Pratis [=Leicester Abbey] in Leicestershire. (14)

Aston's surviving compositions (15) are mostly vocal works, typically for five unaccompanied voices. However, three or four keyboard compositions also survive: *A Hornepype*, *Hugh Ashton's Maske* (widely re-worked, e.g. by William Byrd's in his own keyboard piece *Hugh Aston's Ground*), *My Lady Carey's Dompe*, and *The Short Measure of My Lady Winkfyld's Rounde*. His keyboard works are regarded as of first importance for the period, and arguably more advanced than any continental keyboard compositions of the period. The choral works were also innovative, not least in terms of his extensive and ingenious use of *ostinato* (16) – the repetition of basically the same musical figure or phrase in a particular work or movement in a way that can sound startlingly modern today.



Hugh Aston's *Gaude Virgo Mater Christi* for five voices: opening page of a sixteenth century manuscript copy of the *Medius* (Alto) part, (which in this case is the lead voice). (C) British Library Board. All Rights Reserved. (British Library: Harley MS 1709 f.39: reproduced with permission.)

Though undated, on stylistic grounds most of the compositions seem likely to date from Aston's time in Leicester. However, the surviving choral works have a strongly Marian trend, even though this was becoming less fashionable by the 1520s: this perhaps reflects the emphasis on the Virgin Mary with the requirement that there should be a daily sung Mass in honour of Our Lady at The Newarke.

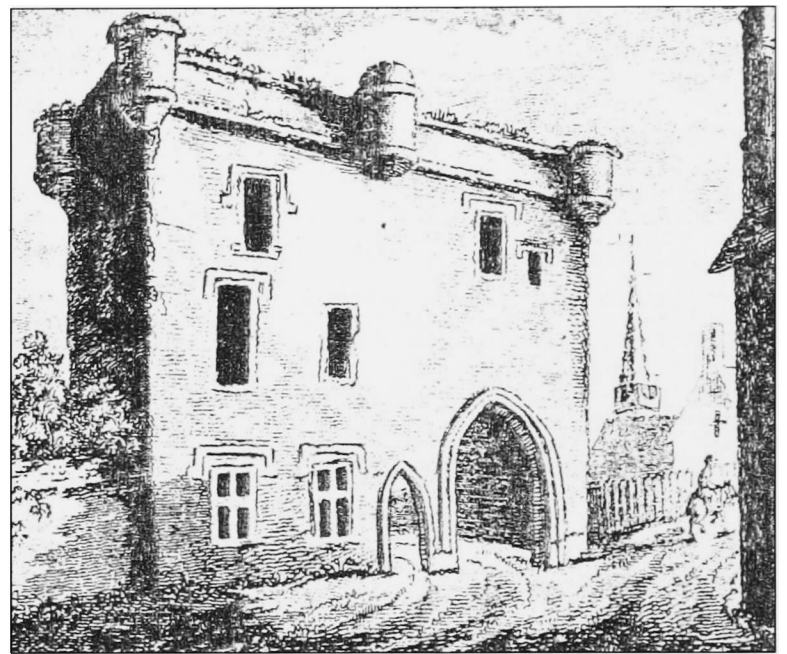
The works include two tolerably complete masses: *Missa Videte manus meas* (six voices) and *Missa Te Deum* (A second incomplete copy of this is titled *Te matrem Dei*, apparently an adapted text - by Aston himself? - creating the equivalent of the *Te Deum* mass, but in honour of the Mother of God). The remaining works are mainly Antiphons on various texts honouring the Virgin Mary: *Ave Maria ancilla Trinitatis*, *Ave Maria divae matris Annae*, *Gaude Mater Matris Christi* (*Gaude Virgo Matris Christi* in some copies), *O Baptista vates Christi*, *Te Deum Laudamus* (*Te Matrem Dei Laudamus* - see *Te Deum* above in one copy; there is also a late Elizabethan version using an English translation of the *Te Deum* in King's College, Cambridge).

In addition there is a devotional song by Aston: *Ave domina sancta Maria*, and an anonymous incomplete Mass in the British Library is attributed by Professor Nick Sandon to Aston because of its apparent relationship to the well-known Hugh Ashton's Maske for keyboard (see above). Among the Antiphons the text in honour of John the Baptist (*O Baptista vates Christi*), is particularly interesting and unusual, and in this respect Nick Sandon points to a possible connection with Launde Priory (now Abbey), Leicestershire, which was dedicated to the Baptist, (17) and in respect of which Aston was to receive a pension from the time of his retirement in around 1546, less than two years before the Dissolution of the Hospital and College of The Newarke, (see above).

However, within Leicester Hugh Aston was not just the director of music at the St Mary's College. By the early 1530s if not earlier, he was also becoming a prominent Leicester citizen, serving on the town council, for most if not all of the last two decades or more of his life representing the First or Southgates ward. This was one of the ten wards of the town, covering the area outside the town walls, covering the area immediately outside The Newarke, in which his Hangman's Lane house was located. The Newarke itself was not part of the town and hence outside the control of the town council, and was to remain so until the eighteenth century. However, as Aston was not living within the excepted area of The Newarke he would have been eligible for election or appointment to civic office within the town.

For the time the council seems very large in relation to the population, and comprised the 'Twenty-four and the Forty-

eight'. While the terminology did not start to be standardised until towards the end of the sixteenth century, the 'Twenty-four' senior members of the council were in effect (and by the 1550s were being routinely referred to as) aldermen two per ward, while the 'Forty-eight' comprised four burgesses per ward. (18) However, the apparently large number was probably necessary as the members of the 'Twenty-four' at least had to undertake a wide range of civic responsibilities personally, including providing the Mayor annually.



The view of the entrance to The Newarke from the direction of Hangman's Lane just outside the walls of The Newarke (and the South Gate of the Town Walls) where we know Aston lived, from John Nichols The History and Antiquities of the County of Leicester, Leicester volume (Newark and Trinity Hospital).

In Bateson's (much abbreviated) summary of the sixteenth century Borough Records of Leicester there are more than two dozen references to Aston and the positions he held, and by 1550 the 'First [later Southgates] Ward' was referred to in the Borough Book of Acts as 'the ward of Mr Hugh Aston'. (19) By 1532 Hugh Aston had probably joined the 'Twenty-four' as an Alderman (and he became a Justice of the Peace, perhaps at the same time), since in that year he was appointed Auditor of Accounts North Quarter 1532-3, continuing in the office through 1533 to 1535. He later served as Auditor of Accounts South Quarter for 1538-9, and then again annually from 1544 to his death in 1558. He was one of the two Town Coroners for two years, 1536-1538, and Steward of the Fair for 1543-4, 1548-9 and 1557-8.

However, Aston's most important civic role was that of Mayor of Leicester for 1541-1542, a significant year for Leicester, as the all-important Market Charter was renewed at a cost of 26s. 8d. The Chamberlains' Accounts for his year of office show the usual expenses of both official

hospitality (a dinner for the visit of the Lord Privy Seal), and the council's own banqueting in the Corpus Christi Hall (now the Guildhall) ('... at Corpus Christi hall for alles after yat Mr Mare had eton weynesson [venison] 8d.'). In view of his profession as a musician it is perhaps significant that it was during Aston's mayoralty that the substantial sum of 24s. was spent by the council on new liveries for the Town Waits (musicians). (20)

Later, Aston was listed in 1550 among the three Justices of the Peace who with the Mayor served as a Portmoot Jury for testing and imposing fines in respect of weights and measures irregularities relating to the south quarter '... being within the ward of Mr Hugh Aston that ys to say without the Southe gate'. (21) In February 1554 he was one of four nominated by the Common Hall to be one of the two representatives of Leicester in the first Parliament of Queen Mary and King Philip to be held in Oxford, though two of other nominees were finally appointed the following month. However, the following year Aston did represent Leicester in the 1555 Westminster Parliament, relatively short but very important in terms of its legislation. (22) This included not just the well-known penal measures for the suppression of heresy, but also the first highways act, from which all contemporary road and traffic law, arguably even local government law and powers, is derived.

His re-appointment to civic offices for 1557-8 indicates that Hugh Aston remained active in civic life at that time, despite his advanced years (he must have been around seventy by then). The exact date of his death in 1558 does not seem to be recorded, but his burial at St. Margaret's Leicester on 17th November 1558 is noted in the diocesan records. (23)

NOTE: *A Commemorative Service is planned to be held in St Margaret's Church, Leicester, at noon on Saturday 15th November 2008 to mark the 450th anniversary of the death of this remarkable musician and civic figure. Both choral and keyboard works by Aston will be included in the service, together with some extracts of the plainsong of the Sarum Rite Requiem Mass which would have been used for Aston's funeral (and which he would have himself performed and conducted very many times through his long musical career). It now seems very likely that in addition De Montfort University will organise a lecture illustrated by some of Aston's works in the Trinity Hospital Chapel on the previous evening. Please check with the venues or in the local press for up-to-date details of these events if you are interested in attending.*

References and Notes:

1. Oliver Neighbour. Hugh Aston's variations on a ground. *Early Music* 1982, 10 (2), pp. 215-216.
2. Nick Sandon. Another mass by Hugh Aston? *Early Music* 1981, 9 (2), pp. 184-191.

3. E.g. John Bergersagel. Aston [Asseton, Asseton, Ashton, Haston], Hugh [Hugo]. *The New Grove Dictionary of Music and Musicians* ed. S. Sadie and J. Tyrrell, 2001, in *Grove Music Online*, Ed. L. Macy. <http://www.grovemusic.com>, accessed 14th March 2008.
4. A number of significant references to Aston have been traced by Dr Roger Bowers in the course of his PhD research: *Choral Institutions within the English Church:- their constitution and development 1340-1500*. (University of East Anglia, 1975, 2 volumes). A full text PDF download of this very important study should be available from the end of 2008 from the British Library Online Thesis Service: <http://www.bl.uk/britishthesis/>.
5. Bowers, 1975, *op. cit.* p. 6067.
6. Sandon 1981, *op. cit.* p. 185.
7. A translation of the part that includes Aston's Deposition is included in A. Hamilton Thompson *The History of the Hospital and the New College of the Annunciation of St Mary in the Newarke, Leicester* (Leicestershire Archaeological Society, 1937), p. 150; a full transcript of the original text is in A. Hamilton Thompson (editor). *Visitations in the Diocese of Lincoln Volume 3, 1517-1531*. (Lincoln Record Society, vol. 37, 1947), p.156 & pp. 222-223.
8. Neil Finn. *The Former St Mary's Vicarage, The Newarke, Leicester: Historic Building Record and Excavation*. (University of Leicester Archaeological Services Report 2005-137 for De Montfort University, 2005).
9. Thompson 1937, *op. cit.* pp. 13-23.
10. Thompson 1937, *op. cit.* pp. 41-81.
11. Bowers, 1975, *op. cit.*
12. F. L. Harrison. *Music in Medieval Britain* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 2nd ed. 1963), pp. 29-30.
13. Bowers, 1975, *op. cit.* pp. 6067-6068.
14. Sandon, 1981, *op. cit.* p. 185.
15. Sandon, 1981, *op. cit.* p.186-191. Prof. Sandon has now published critical and performing editions of most of Aston's surviving choral works: see <http://www.anticoedition.co.uk/> for details of these.
16. Sandon, 1981, *op. cit.* p. 189-191.
17. Sandon, 1981, *op. cit.* p. 185.
18. M. Bateson. *Records of the Borough of Leicester, Vol. III. 1509 - 1603*. (Cambridge, University Press, 1905), particularly pp. xvii-xxii.
19. Bateson, 1905, *op. cit.* particularly the list of office holders through the century in pp. 458-487; the *Book of Acts* quote is at p. 61.
20. Bateson, 1905, *op. cit.* p. 49.
21. Bateson, 1905, *op. cit.* p. 62-63.
22. Bateson, 1905, *op. cit.* p. 76-77, p. 460.
23. G.A.J. Hodgett. *The State of the ex-Religious and former Chantry Priests in the Diocese of Lincoln 1547-1574*. (Lincoln Record Society, vol. 53, 1959), p.142.